

Your First Game

A guided walkthrough — read this at the table, out loud

3 PLAYERS ABOUT 20 MINUTES TO LEARN TOBY SIKO

– How to use this booklet

Don't read the rulebook first. Sit down with the box, put this booklet in the middle of the table, and work through it aloud. It sets the game up with you and then plays the first three rounds alongside you, introducing each rule at the moment you need it.

The walkthrough is written for **three players** — we'll call them **Ada**, **Bex** and **Cy**; substitute your own names. At two or four players everything works the same way; the setup table in the rulebook covers the differences.

Two things to leave in the box for now: the **map objectives** and **personal objectives** modules. They're good, and they're for your third game.

Once you've played, the rulebook is the reference — every section number in these pages points into it.

1 Set the table up together

STEP 1 · THE CARDS

Split the deck by rank, not by suit

Find every card of ranks **3 to 10** — that's your **starting deck**. Ranks **11 to 20** are the **advanced deck** — the full range, whatever the player count. Put ranks 1 and 2 back in the box; they belong to the four-player starting deck.

Ranks 3–10 give 32 cards and you only need 30. Shuffle the four rank-3 cards, keep two at random, and box the others. That keeps the starting deck at 30 cards.

STEP 2 · YOUR HAND

Draft ten cards you'll keep all game

Deal ten starting-deck cards to each player. Now draft: **keep 4, pass the rest clockwise**. From the six you receive, **keep 6, pass 4**. Then **keep 8, pass 2**. Then keep the last two. You end with ten cards.

Say this out loud: *these ten cards are your civilization for the whole game. You will play them, pick them back up, and play them again. You'll only change them by buying better ones later — one at a time, and never more than ten.*

Drafting well is a skill for game two. For now, a rough guide: pairs and consecutive ranks are worth more than high cards on their own, because they let you play more cards at once.

STEP 3 · YOUR BOARD

Load all twenty units, top tier first

Take a player board and fill all five tiers — **2, 3, 5, 5, 5** from the top. Every unit you'll ever place is here. Put the **ascension coins** on their printed spots: 1, 2, 3, 4.

RESERVE

empty from the top band down

FOOD

MOVES

2

cards

Tribe

2 units

free

1

3

cards

Settlement

3 units

2

4

cards

Kingdom

5 units

3

5

cards

Empire

5 units

4

6

cards

Civilization

5 units

5

Each recycle your people eat your current tier's coins only — food is not cumulative.
Free moves refresh every turn.

GOLD

VICTORY ROW

Your reserve empties from the top band down. The tier you are currently drawing from prints four numbers: the meld you may play, your free moves, the gold your people cost to feed, and the highest rank you may buy. Right now that is Tribe – melds of two, one free move, food free, cap 12.

Say this out loud: *this board is the engine. Emptying a tier makes you stronger and more expensive at the same moment — and pays you a one-off ascension coin for doing it.*

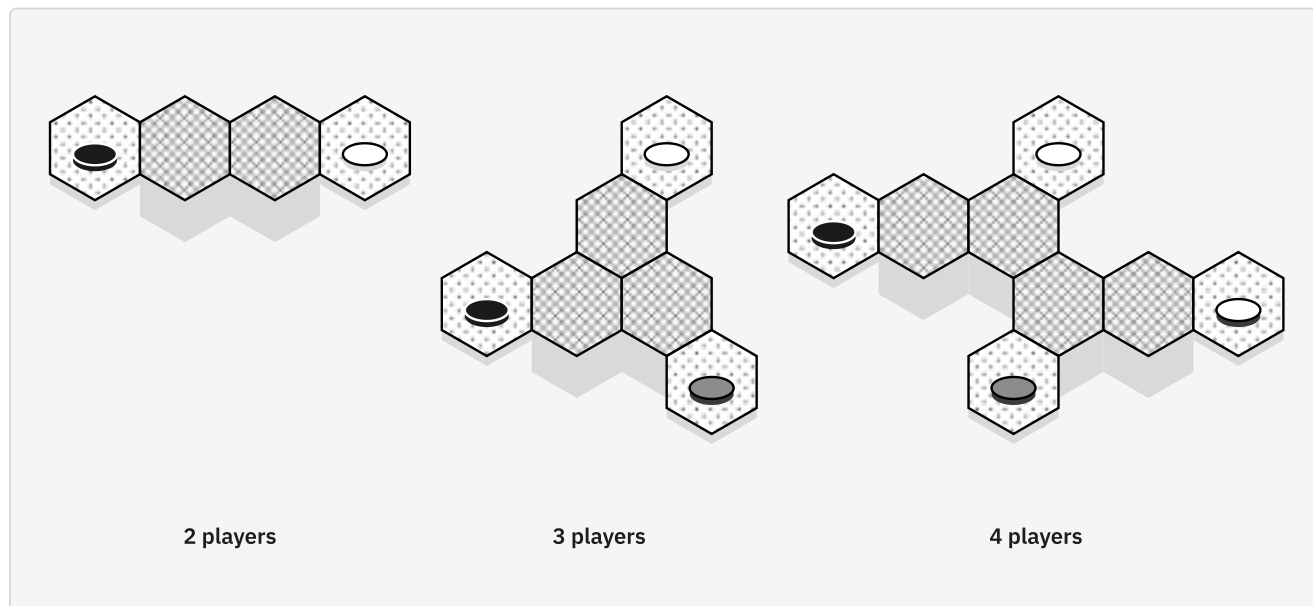
STEP 4 · THE MAP

Three Mountains, three Plains

Take three **Mountain** tiles and put them in a triangle in the middle of the table. Now put one **Plains** against each outer face of the triangle, spaced as in the picture, so that **every Plains is three tiles from every other**.

Each player takes one unit from their top band and puts it on a Plains — that's their homeland.

Why three apart: *cards only act next to your civilization. Three apart means nobody can be attacked in the opening rounds, whatever they draw.*



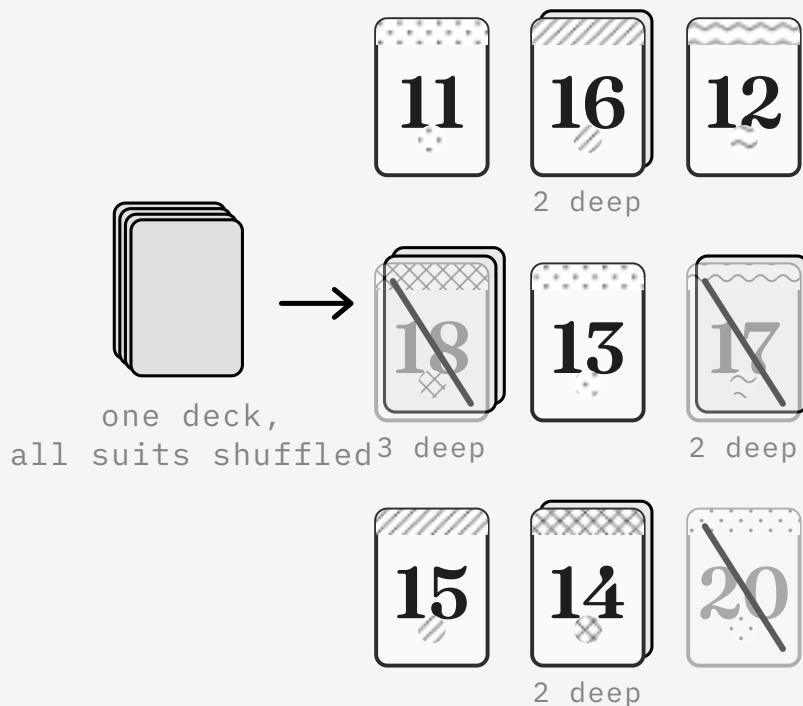
The starting layouts. One Mountain per player in the middle, one Plains per player around it — and every start three tiles from every other, which is what keeps you out of reach in the opening rounds.

STEP 5 • THE SUPPLY AND THE MARKET

Tiles in the open, nine cards face up

Sort the remaining tiles into four open piles by terrain, in easy reach of everyone. This is the **tile supply** — nothing is hidden and nothing is rationed. When you need a Forest, you take a Forest, until the Forests run out.

Now shuffle the whole advanced deck together, face down. Deal **nine cards face up in a 3×3 grid** beside it. That is the market — a spread of ranks, not one per suit. Leave a gap beside it for the **shared pile**, which starts empty.



your rank cap is 16: the taller cards are visible, not buyable
a draw covers the highest rank showing – nobody chooses

One shuffled deck, nine positions. Every research turns a card onto the position showing the highest rank – burying it. Nobody chooses where it lands, so the top of the market keeps sinking out of reach. Your tier's rank cap decides how much of the spread you can actually take; the rest is visible and out of bounds.

STEP 6 • WHO GOES FIRST

Hand out the dice

Pick a start player – Ada, say. She takes initiative die “1”. The others take 2 and 3. You're ready.

2 Round one — play it with us

Everyone still has a unit sitting in Tribe — setup spent one of the two — so everybody's meld limit is **2**. You may play one card or two, never more. Note how short that is: the first unit any of you settles clears Tribe and lifts that player to melds of three.

The card phase

Ada leads, then Bex, then Cy. Nobody may pass, and — unlike most trick-taking games — **nobody has to follow suit**. Play whatever combination you like.

What counts as a legal meld? Just one rule: the ranks must form an **unbroken run**. Duplicates are free, suits are irrelevant. At limit 2 that means a single card, two of the same rank, or two consecutive ranks.

- ADA plays **5 of Plains + 6 of Plains** — the run 5-6.
- BEX plays **8 of Mountain + 8 of Ocean** — the run 8, doubled.
- CY plays a single **4 of Mountain**.

Now resolve it. **Highest total wins** — add the ranks up. Bex played $8 + 8 = \mathbf{16}$, Ada $5 + 6 = \mathbf{11}$, Cy a single $4 = \mathbf{4}$. **Bex wins the trick**. She takes die 1, Ada die 2, Cy die 3.

Ada matched Bex's two cards and lost, so one of the two cards **she already played** is **set aside**: she chooses which, it pays her **1 gold** instead of acting on the map, and it goes face down to the shared pile. Cy played fewer than the winner, so he gives up nothing. That rule counts CARDS, not the total — Ada played two and so did Bex.

Notice: *Cy could have won this trick with a single card, if it had been a 17 or better. One big card is a real play. But it would have been one card to spend on the map afterwards, against Bex's two — which is the choice the whole game turns on.*

The map phase

Here's the move that makes Blink what it is: **you now spend those same cards**, one by one, as your actions on the map. Each card does one of four things: **settle** a unit, **explore** a tile, **attack** a rival, or **take 1 gold** — always on terrain matching its suit, always next to your civilization.

The winner spends every card they played, and so does anyone who played *fewer* than the winner. Only a player who **matched** the winner and lost gives one up — set aside for a gold, as Ada just did. The player whose meld **ranked last takes 1 gold**. Act in initiative order.

BEX — 2 CARDS, AND SHE WON

Only Plains and Mountain are on the table yet, so her **Mountain** card is the one that can settle: the Mountain beside her homeland is in reach, and she takes a unit from her top band. Mountain holds one, so that tile is hers alone now. She spends her **Ocean** card on an **explore**: she picks an empty space beside her civilization, checks that it touches at least two tiles already on the table, takes an Ocean tile from the supply, and puts it down empty for now. Both her cards reached the map — that is what winning the trick is worth, along with going first.

ADA — 2 CARDS, ONE OF THEM SET ASIDE

She keeps the **6 of Plains** and sets the 5 aside. The only Plains she can reach is her own homeland, so she settles the 6 by **stacking** a second unit on it — Plains holds three. The 5 goes face down to the shared pile and pays her **1 gold**: that is the price of matching Bex's two cards and losing.

Notice: *at the start there is no Forest and no Ocean anywhere. The only way to use those cards is to build the ground first — that is what exploring is for, and it is why nobody's hand is dead on turn one.*

CY — 1 CARD, AND LAST PLACE

His single ranked last this trick, so he takes **1 gold** for that. He cashes the 4 of Mountain for a second gold — nothing on the map is worth reaching for yet. He has built nothing and is not behind; he's saving.

To finish: pass the lead to Bex. Put your played cards face up in front of you — that pile is your **personal discard**, and it will become your next hand.

What just happened: *one meld did two jobs. Bex's slightly higher card bought her initiative and a third card to spend. Cy's caution came last and paid him for it. That trade — tempo now against resources later — is the whole game.*

3

Round two — spend them your way

Bex leads. Before you play, here is the rule that new players most often miss.

A meld is a **combination of cards**, nothing more. Once the trick is settled, the meld has done its job — each card is then spent **on its own**, in any order you like, and each one sees the map as the last one left it. Explore a tile with one card and settle it with the next. Send one card to a border and cash the other for a coin. The meld decides *how much* you do, never *what* you do.

Say this out loud: *every card is the same question — is it a person, or is it gold? There is no wrong terrain to hold cards for: a card with no useful place on the map is a coin, and coins are never wasted.*

Play round two normally. Four things to watch for as they come up:

- **A card with nowhere useful to go** — wrong terrain, or boxed in — simply **takes 1 gold** instead. You are never stuck.
- **Landing on a rival's tile** is an **attack**, not a move — and an attack is a **duel**. You each put one card from hand face down and turn them together: your rank against their rank plus the ground (Plains and Ocean +0, Forest +1, Mountain +2). Higher wins; level goes to the defender. Win and *one* of their units goes home — and if that was the last unit there, the tile is yours: settle it on the spot. Both cards go to their owners' discards, back in your hand next time it recycles. Taking a tile always takes more than one turn. (You won't manage it this round — the Mountain is in the way, which is why it's there, and it defends at +2.)
- **Your free move.** Once per turn at Tribe — no card needed — you may move one unit: across your own connected units onto a free tile beside them, or across open Ocean. Never onto a rival.
- **Your top tier empties fast.** Tribe holds only two units and setup already spent one, so the first unit you settle clears it — take the **1 ascension coin** from the Settlement row. Your meld limit goes to **3**, your free moves to **2** — and your food bill starts at **1 gold** per recycle. You pay whatever your current band shows and nothing more.

4

Round three — spend a coin

By now someone has two or three gold. Here's what it buys.

The most important purchase is an **upgrade**, and it is a straight trade: **your worst card out, a better one in**. Retire the **lowest-ranked card in your hand** into your **victory row**, pay **1 gold**, and take any one of the nine face-up market cards **straight into your hand**. You still hold exactly ten cards; one of them is just much better — and you can play it next round.

It has to come out of your **hand** — cards you have already played to the table this turn are spent, and cannot be retired. So a turn where you dump your whole hand is a turn you do not research.

You never choose *which* card leaves: it is always your lowest. That is what makes research feel like progress rather than shopping — the old idea is what pays for the new one, and nothing reaches your victory row that was not once the worst card you owned.

Early on that means giving up a 3 or a 4. Later, when your hand is all upgrades, your lowest card *is* a good one. Don't hold back waiting for that: a card in the row is a point whatever its rank, so researching whenever you can afford it beats saving up for a perfect one.

The card you retired is not wasted — it sits in your victory row and **scores at the end of the game**: a point for being there, and, once you hold three, its rank may land in the centre slot and score again. Or you can spend it later for a one-shot effect, at the cost of never scoring it. One of those effects is declared at the very top of a round, before anybody plays a card, so it is a bet rather than an answer; the other two — extra units, and taking gold — are used when you can already see the board. That choice is the heart of the game's second half; ignore it for now and just keep them.

The frontier pays. *Explore with a card of rank 10 or under — anything from your starting deck — and take 1 gold. Your weakest cards are worth something on the edge of the map. Once you start buying upgrades, that tap closes.*

Gold also pays for: fortifying a unit against one attack (1) — a coin on a unit stops an attack outright, with no duel at all — researching, and, from the moment you empty your first band, **feeding your people**. Put the coins on your band's food slots during your turn; when your hand recycles, that is what your people eat.

A warning worth hearing early: *expanding fast is how you lose your first game. Every band you empty moves you onto a costlier row — free, then 1, then 2, then 3 gold every time your hand recycles, and you pay only the row you are on. Losing tricks pays you a coin per unused card, so falling a little behind is how you stay fed.*

5 Now play on

You know enough. Play to the end — the game finishes when someone places their last unit or a suit's advanced deck runs out, then you finish the round and play one more.

At the end, count: **1 point per unit on the map**, plus the **centre card of your victory row** (once you have three or more), plus **3 points for each terrain where you have the most units**. Gold breaks ties.

Then read the rulebook. It will take twenty minutes and it will make sense, because you've already seen every part of it move.

* Six things first-timers get wrong

Treating gold as a fallback.

Cashing good cards on purpose is how food, fortresses and research get paid for. The strongest players convert constantly. (§06)

Trying to win every trick.

Coming last pays you a gold, and you'll need it. Deliberately playing a single is a real strategy, not a failure. (§04)

Expecting to capture a tile in one turn.

One card removes one defender and places nothing. You empty a tile one round and settle it the next. (§06)

Emptying bands as fast as possible.

Bigger melds put you on a costlier row, and that gold has three other jobs. Growth is a decision, not a goal. (§09)

Hoarding cards in the victory row and never spending one.

They're also your emergency gold and your trick insurance. A row of five you never touched may mean you played too safely — though every card is worth a point on its own, so spending one always costs you something. (§10)

Forgetting the discard is your next hand.

What you play this round is what you'll hold next time round. Cards bought late arrive later than you think. (§09)